A typical Provence concoction, this mussel and fennel soup harmoniously combines seafood and vegetables in a fragrant broth.

mussel and fennel soup

SERVES 4 **PREP TIME** 15 MINS **COOK** 45 MINS **FREEZE** UP TO 1 MONTH

2¼lb (1kg) fresh mussels
2 cups dry white wine
4 medium, ripe tomatoes
3 tbsp olive oil
1 leek, chopped
2 sprigs of fresh flat-leaf parsley
2 sprigs of thyme
1 bay leaf
¼ small fennel bulb, chopped
2in (5cm) piece dried orange peel
fine sea salt and freshly ground black pepper
1 large floury potato, peeled and chopped
pinch of saffron strands

1 Rinse and debeard the mussels. Place them in a large saucepan and add the wine. Cover the pan, put over high heat, and cook for 5–6 minutes, shaking occasionally, until the mussels open (discard any that remain closed). Remove from the heat. Line a sieve with muslin or cheesecloth and place over a bowl. Transfer the mussels into the sieve and leave until cool enough to handle, then remove and discard the shells. Reserve both the mussels and the cooking liquid.

2 Pierce the tomatoes with a knife, put them in a bowl, and pour over boiling water to cover. Leave for 1 minute, then drain and peel away the skins. Quarter, remove and discard the seeds, and chop the flesh. Heat the oil in a large sauté pan over medium heat. Add the tomatoes, leek, herbs, fennel, and orange peel and season. Cook until softened, stirring frequently.

3 Add the mussel cooking liquid to the pan, then 2 cups of just-boiled water. Bring to a simmer. Add the potato and cook until soft. Remove from the heat, let cool a little, then remove the herbs and orange peel. Mash the potato pieces into the soup to thicken.

4 Soften the saffron in a small bowl with a spoonful of soup, then stir it back in. Taste and adjust the seasoning, add the mussels, reheat gently, and serve immediately.